UPSC CIVIL SERVICES · DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

SUNDAY, 18 OCTOBER 2026

17 must-know stories, 26 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 502 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

Open this brief online: summaries, Ask Intel and practice MCQs

MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Directs States, UTs To Notify Anti-Human Trafficking Units As Police Station

The Supreme Court directed all States and Union Territories to officially notify Anti-Human Trafficking Units as police stations under the law. The order aims to strengthen investigations into human trafficking and improve the protection of women and children exploited commercially. A bench of Justice J.B. Pardiwala and Justice R. Mahadevan issued this direction during a hearing on October 15, 2026. The directive follows a submission by Senior Advocate Aparna Bhat pointing out that the Court's earlier judgment required giving these units police station status. Without formal police station status, some Anti-Human Trafficking Units faced limitations in their authority to register criminal cases and investigate. The latest direction is part of monitoring the Victim Protection Plan framed under Article 142 of the Constitution in Prajwala v. Union of India. States and UTs must also notify recognized welfare institutions under the Immoral Traffic Prevention Act, prepare social worker lists, and appoint nodal officers. The Court directed the Union Government to coordinate with States, ensure compliance, and submit a fresh status report by the next hearing on December 14, 2026.

When: October 15, 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court Bench (Justice J.B. Pardiwala and Justice R. Mahadevan), Senior Advocate Aparna Bhat · **Prelims:** Case name: Prajwala v. Union of India; Key statutes mentioned: Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, 1956 (Sections 15(6A) and 17A); Constitutional provision used: Article 142

> ***Why it matters —*** *Grants Anti-Human Trafficking Units independent legal powers to register FIRs and conduct seamless investigations.; Strengthens the enforcement of the Supreme Court's Victim Protection Plan for women and children.*

Static — Article 142 of the Constitution empowers the Supreme Court to pass any decree or order necessary for doing complete justice in any pending cause or matter. The Immoral Traffic Prevention Act of 1956 is the premier legislation in India for preventing commercial sexual exploitation and trafficking. Anti-Human Trafficking Units are specialised police wings set up at the district level to specifically tackle trafficking crimes.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

indianmasterminds.com: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Private complaints over false election affidavits need no official sanction: Supreme Court

Private citizens can file criminal complaints against candidates for submitting false affidavits during nominations without any official sanction. A Supreme Court bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu held that Section 125-A of the RPA 1951 is outside Section 195 CrPC. The core issue involved whether courts could take cognizance of private complaints under Section 200 CrPC for false election affidavits. The appeal arose from a Karnataka High Court judgment quashing Rajkumar Madki's private complaint against MLA Dr Shailendra Beldale. The High Court previously held that only the Election Commission could complain under Section 125-A and voters must file an election petition. The Supreme Court ruled that courts cannot expand offences requiring public servant complaints by implication as Section 125-A lacks inclusion in Section 195 CrPC. EC guidelines or press notes cannot bind judicial interpretation, and Parliament did not restrict such prosecutions. The apex court declined to revive the specific case against Beldale as records rebutted the allegations and conviction prospects were remote. Magistrates retain full powers to deal with any frivolous or harassing complaints filed by private individuals in the future.

When: October 16, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi and Karnataka · **Who:** Supreme Court bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu, Rajkumar Madki, Dr Shailendra Beldale · **Prelims:** Offence section involved: Section 125-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951.; CrPC section discussed for restrictions: Section 195 CrPC.; Complainant in the appeal: Rajkumar Madki.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Enhances electoral accountability by empowering ordinary citizens and voters to directly challenge false candidate disclosures.; Clarifies the statutory boundary between the Representation of the People Act and the Code of Criminal*

Procedure regarding offences.

Static — The Election Commission of India is an autonomous constitutional body established under Article 324 of the Constitution to superintend and conduct elections. Section 125-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, penalizes filing false affidavits or concealing information during candidate nomination. Section 195 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) restricts courts from taking cognizance of certain offences without a public servant's written complaint.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

deccanherald.com: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court bars mid-term fee hikes in professional courses except in extraordinary circumstances

The ruling was issued in response to concerns over the heavy financial burden sudden fee hikes place on households. The Supreme Court ruled against mid-term fee hikes in professional courses, permitting them only in extraordinary circumstances. For the overwhelming majority of households, the fee payable for a professional course constitutes a substantial part of the family's income and savings, the court observes

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court of India · **Prelims:** The Supreme Court barred mid-term fee hikes in professional courses.; Exceptions to the rule are permitted only in extraordinary circumstances.

Why it matters — *Protects middle-class and low-income households from unexpected financial shocks during professional education.; Reaffirms judicial commitment against the arbitrary commercialization of professional courses.*

Static — The Supreme Court of India is the highest judicial forum and final court of appeal under the Constitution of India. It has original, appellate and advisory jurisdiction as mandated under Articles 124 to 147 of the Constitution. Article 142 of the Constitution empowers the Supreme Court to pass any decree or order necessary for doing complete justice in any pending case.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Education · Prelims angle: Judgment

The Hindu: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Reviews Tribunal's Order Directing Fresh Consideration for IAS Secretary Empanelment Under Central Staffing Scheme. Judicial Review Limited to Illegality, Procedural Irregularity, or Proved Mala Fides; Seniority Not Sole Determinant for Secr

The matter came to the Supreme Court following a tribunal directive that ordered fresh consideration for an officer's empanelment. The Supreme Court examined a tribunal order concerning IAS Secretary empanelment under the Central Staffing Scheme, restricting judicial review to illegality, procedural irregularity, or mala fides.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Supreme Court of India · **Prelims:** The case involves IAS Secretary empanelment under the Central Staffing Scheme.; Judicial review in such administrative matters is limited to illegality, procedural irregularity, or proved mala fides.; Seniority is not the sole determinant for Secretary-level empanelment.

Why it matters — *Reaffirms the separation of powers by limiting judicial interference in executive appointments.; Clarifies that seniority alone does not guarantee high-level bureaucratic empanelment under the Central Staffing Scheme.*

Static — The Central Staffing Scheme governs the deputation of IAS and other All India Services officers to senior posts in the central government ministries and departments. Empanelment at the level of Joint Secretary, Additional Secretary, and Secretary is carried out through a rigorous evaluation process overseen by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet. Judicial review of administrative actions and expert committee decisions is restricted to grounds of illegality, irrationality, procedural impropriety, and unproven mala fides.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme, Judgment

Lawtext: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

SC: No need for nod to prosecute govt official seeking bribe

The Supreme Court ruled that public servants caught demanding bribes do not enjoy the shield of prior sanction for prosecution. The ruling aims to clarify that statutory protection under the Prevention of Corruption Act prevents persecution for official decisions, not criminal acts. A bench comprising Justices SVN Bhatti and N V Anjaria interpreted Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act, inserted in 2018. Section 17A prohibits investigating agencies from conducting inquiries into public servants' duties without official approval. The court dismissed an appeal by a Rajasthan police constable challenging an FIR and chargesheet for allegedly demanding a bribe of Rs 1.5 lakh. The bench emphasized that demanding a bribe is a pure criminal act disconnected from official functions and lacks linkage with public duties. The court accepted arguments presented by Rajasthan additional advocate general Sansriti Pathak. Justice Anjaria wrote that the appellant's act does not fall under Section 17A's protective umbrella, meaning proceedings are not vitiated for want of sanction.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** New Delhi, Rajasthan · **Who:** Justices SVN Bhatti and N V Anjaria, Sansriti Pathak · **Prelims:** Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act was inserted into the statute in 2018.; The Supreme Court bench that delivered the ruling consisted of Justices SVN Bhatti and N V Anjaria.; The case involved a Rajasthan police constable who allegedly demanded a bribe of Rs 1.5 lakh.

Why it matters — *Strengthens anti-corruption enforcement by removing procedural roadblocks for investigating agencies targeting corrupt officials caught in the act.; Clarifies the precise scope of Section 17A, preventing its misuse as an omnibus shield for*

criminal misconduct.

Static — The Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, is the primary legislation in India enacted to combat corruption in government agencies and public sector businesses. Section 17A was introduced into the Prevention of Corruption Act via an amendment in 2018 to protect honest public servants from malicious or vexatious prosecutions for policy decisions taken in good faith. Prior sanction from the competent government authority under Section 19 of the Act is generally required before a court can take cognizance of offenses alleged against public servants.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution

Times of India: read the source

Governance & Policy

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Census 2027: The pressures of counting India

Field workers have reported that ground conditions and supervisory instructions are severely impacting data collection under the digital Census system. Enumerators conducting the Census 2027 are facing major on-ground hurdles such as heat, connectivity issues, and safety concerns. Vijaita Singh reports on the challenges

When: 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Enumerators and field workers · **Prelims:** The Census exercise is conducted using a digital system designed for real-time monitoring.; Field challenges reported include heat, connectivity issues, and safety concerns.; Supervisory instructions are also noted to affect data collection.

Why it matters — *Highlights the practical ground-level operational challenges in implementing large-scale digital governance initiatives in India.; Emphasizes the welfare and safety needs of frontline enumerators who form the backbone of national statistical data collection.*

Static — The Census of India is the most comprehensive source of demographic, social, and economic data in the country. It is conducted every ten years under the provisions of the Census Act, 1948 by the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner, Ministry of Home Affairs. The Census process involves two phases: Houselisting and Housing Census, followed by the actual Population Enumeration.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

The Hindu: read the source

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Centre issues advisory to Meta, asks it to overhaul content promotion system on Facebook, Instagram

The Centre directed social media giant Meta to overhaul the content promotion systems on Facebook and Instagram. The advisory was issued by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on October 10. MeitY flagged that recommendation algorithms were leading to disproportionate exposure of users to a single or limited set of narratives. The government asked Meta to provide an appropriate diversity of relevant and credible information to platform users. The ministry raised concerns over content relating to ongoing public events being prominently displayed and recommended. Flagged content includes old or selectively edited visuals, misleading claims about emergencies, and uncontextualised law-and-order material. Meta was instructed to strengthen mechanisms for rapid identification, review, and escalation of viral content that could cause public disorder. The company was told to cooperate with law enforcement agencies by providing information within timelines prescribed under the IT Rules, 2021.

When: October 10, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) and Meta · **Prelims:** MeitY issued the advisory to Meta on October 10.; The advisory cites the Information Technology Act, 2000 and IT Rules, 2021.; Meta owns Instagram and Facebook.

Why it matters — *Highlights the growing regulatory scrutiny on algorithmic amplification and recommendation engines of big tech firms.; Seeks to curb the spread of misinformation, doctored videos, and out-of-context visuals during sensitive public events.*

Static — The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) is responsible for policy formulation, promotion, and rules regarding information technology and electronics in India. The Information Technology Act, 2000 is the primary law in India dealing with cybercrime and e-commerce. The Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021 mandate due diligence by social media intermediaries.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Governance & Policy

Times of India: read the source · also reported by Hindustan Times

International Relations

GS2 MAKE NOTES

U.S. President wants 60 days to analyse impact of Russia sanctions law, says Marco Rubio

US President Donald Trump wants a 60-day period to analyse the impact of imposing sanctions on Russia and tariffs on other countries. Secretary of State Marco Rubio stated this on Saturday ahead of his week-long tour of Uzbekistan and India. The analysis involves evaluating what these measures mean for both the global economy and the US economy. On Friday, Trump signed an executive order waiving key provisions of the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, also known as the Graham Act. The Graham Act had authorised punitive tariffs on countries purchasing Russian oil, and the waiver offers relief to India. The executive order states that waivers remain in effect until the President or Secretary of State determine further action is appropriate in consultation with other officials. Rubio noted the Graham Act included waivers to study global pressures such as the Iran war, Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia, and the Ukraine-Russia war. Rubio acknowledged that countries like India have voluntarily diversified their energy portfolios but still need Russian energy because pivoting is difficult.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** Washington, USA; India; Uzbekistan · **Who:** Donald Trump, Marco Rubio · **Prelims:** The sanctions law discussed is the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, also referred to as the Graham Act.; Marco Rubio serves as the US Secretary of State.; The US President signed an executive order waiving key provisions of the Graham Act on Friday.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides temporary relief to India from potential US secondary tariffs for purchasing Russian oil.; Highlights the strategic balancing act in US foreign policy regarding energy security, global inflation, and sanctions enforcement.*

Static — United States foreign policy on sanctions is primarily executed through executive orders and specific legislation passed by Congress. Secondary sanctions and legislative acts like CAATSA or similar specific bills often target third-party nations engaging in trade with sanctioned entities like Russia and Iran. India-US bilateral relations encompass strategic, defence, and economic cooperation, with energy security remaining a key area of diplomatic engagement.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

Hindustan Times: read the source · also reported by WION, Times of India

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Deferred 100% US tariffs offer only temporary relief to India as Russian oil imports fall

Washington deferred up to 100% tariffs under the new Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act (Graham Act) that could have targeted India for buying Russian oil. Indian refiners cut Russian crude imports by a third from their July peak, falling from about 2.7 million barrels a day to 1.8 million barrels. The deferral offers only temporary relief, leaving the secondary sanctions law in place as leverage for future US trade negotiations. India's crude import bill surged 31.6% in September to $15.4 billion due to higher prices and shifting to more expensive alternative suppliers like the US, West Africa, and West Asia. The average crude price of the Indian basket rose 28.71% from $90.19 a barrel in August to $116.09 per barrel in September. Experts warn that India must protect its energy security and avoid trading permanent concessions for temporary tariff waivers.

When: September and October 2026 · **Where:** India and United States · **Who:** Donald Trump, Piyush Goyal, Ajay Srivastava · **Prelims:** Imports of discounted Russian crude fell by a third from their peak in July to about 1.8 million barrels a day.; India's crude import bill rose 31.6% in September to $15.4 billion from $11.7 billion in August.; The average crude price of the Indian basket increased to $116.09 per barrel in September 2026.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the vulnerability of India's energy security to shifting geopolitical sanctions and US legislative pressure.; Demonstrates how trade negotiations and tariff leverages are used by major economies to influence energy importers.*

Static — India is the world's third-largest consumer and importer of crude oil, relying on imports for over 85 percent of its domestic requirement. The Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas monitors India's domestic petroleum product consumption and import data. Secondary sanctions are punitive measures imposed by a country on third-party entities and nations that engage in economic transactions with a sanctioned state.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations, Economy · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

Hindustan Times: read the source

Social Justice & Welfare

GS2 MAKE NOTES

'Take This Very Seriously': SC Slams States, UTs Over Menstrual Hygiene Rights

The Supreme Court expressed severe displeasure with states and Union territories for failing to respond to the Centre about implementing its judgment on menstrual hygiene. A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan noted that states and UTs have not responded to the Centre regarding how the judgment is being executed. The court warned that if states and UTs fail to respond by the next hearing on December 14, it will issue contempt notices to the concerned chief secretaries. The apex court previously declared menstrual hygiene and health as a facet of the fundamental right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution. The January 30 judgment aims to protect young girls, particularly in remote areas, who drop out of education due to menstrual hygiene issues. The court directed the Centre to take up the issue seriously, gather written information from states and UTs, and study the verdict again. In September, the Centre reported that 30,458 gender-segregated toilets with washing facilities have been constructed in schools, with 4,236 under construction.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan, Aishwarya Bhati · **Prelims:** Menstrual hygiene is recognized as a part of the fundamental right to life under Article 21.; The Supreme Court bench handling the matter consists of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan.; The Centre informed the court that 30,458 gender-segregated toilets have been constructed in schools.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reinforces the judicial expansion of Article 21 to encompass vital health and sanitation rights.; Addresses structural issues like school dropouts among young girls due to inadequate menstrual hygiene facilities.*

Static — Article 21 of the Constitution guarantees the protection of life and personal liberty, which the Supreme Court has progressively expanded to include various facets like health, privacy, and now menstrual hygiene. The Supreme Court of India is the highest judicial forum and final court of appeal under the Constitution, possessing power of judicial review to enforce fundamental rights. Under the federal structure of India, implementation of various social welfare, health, and school infrastructure policies heavily relies on administrative action by state governments and Union territories.

Syllabus: GS2: Social Justice & Welfare, Polity & Constitution

msn.com: read the source · also reported by Deccan Herald, The Hindu

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India bars sugar-based ethanol in 2026-27 tender, cuts maize incentive

State-run oil marketing companies have excluded sugarcane juice, sugar syrup, and B-heavy molasses from the ethanol procurement tender for 2026-27. The central government directed zero sugar diversion to safeguard domestic sugar availability and curb price spikes caused by poor monsoon rains. The decision highlights the ongoing trade-off between domestic food security and the ambitious target of nationwide 20 percent ethanol blending. Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited issued the tender on behalf of oil marketing companies to procure roughly 11 billion litres of ethanol. The tender permits ethanol bids produced strictly from maize, broken rice, Food Corporation of India surplus rice, and C-heavy molasses. Procurement pricing for maize-based ethanol was slashed to Rs 68.86 per litre from Rs 71.86 by trimming the incentive to Rs 2.79. Deficit rainfall in key sugarcane-growing states like Maharashtra and Karnataka raised serious alarms about domestic cane yield and sugar stocks. Meeting the 20 percent blending target will now heavily depend on grain distilleries, feedstock supply adequacy, and processing margins.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi, Maharashtra, Karnataka · **Who:** Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), Government of India · **Prelims:** The tender restricts feedstocks to maize, broken rice, FCI surplus rice, and C-heavy molasses.; Maize-based ethanol procurement price was reduced from Rs 71.86 to Rs 68.86 per litre.; The ethanol supply year 2026-27 runs from November 2026 to October 2027.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Prioritises national food security and price control over biofuel diversion during deficit agricultural seasons.; Shifts ethanol production reliance toward grains, directly affecting distillery capacity utilisation and miller margins.*

Static — The Ethanol Blended Petrol Programme was launched in 2003 by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas to reduce oil import dependency and vehicular emissions. The National Policy on Biofuels 2018 advanced the target of achieving 20 percent ethanol blending in petrol (E20) to 2025-26 from 2030. First-generation (1G) biofuels are derived from edible biomass like sugarcane and grains, whereas second-generation (2G) biofuels utilise non-food biomass such as agricultural residues.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Infrastructure & Energy, Agriculture & Allied

The Hindu: read the source · free copy on news18.com

GS3 MAKE NOTES

What does RBI's repo rate hike to 5.50% mean for India's economy and future inflation?

SBI Funds Management projected that the RBI may need to raise the benchmark repo rate to at least 6.25 per cent to contain inflation. This assessment follows the RBI raising the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50 per cent earlier in the month. Retail inflation rose to 5.54 per cent in September from 4.83 per cent in August, while wholesale inflation accelerated to 11.39 per cent. The report stated that policy rates need to move higher to enable a real rate of around 1 per cent. Headline CPI remains nearly 120 basis points above the 4 per cent target despite a forward estimate of 5.20 per cent for FY27. The RBI projected inflation at 6 per cent in Q3 FY27 and 5.7 per cent in Q4 FY27 due to ongoing price pressures. Elevated crude oil prices, potential food inflation, and strong domestic demand could push inflation above the 6 per cent upper tolerance limit. Surplus banking-system liquidity could weaken the effectiveness of rate hikes, requiring strict liquidity management. The next RBI Monetary Policy Committee meeting is scheduled for December 2-4 to review fresh inflation data.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India, SBI Funds Management · **Prelims:** The repo rate was raised by 25 basis points to 5.50 per cent.; Retail inflation rose to 5.54 per cent in September.; Wholesale inflation accelerated to 11.39 per cent in September.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the ongoing battle against sticky retail and wholesale inflation in India.; Signals that future rate cuts are off the table with further hikes or holds expected.*

Static — The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is India's central banking institution established under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) is a statutory body constituted under Section 45ZB of the RBI Act to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The inflation target for India is fixed by the Central Government in consultation with the RBI, set at 4 per cent with a tolerance band of +/- 2 percentage points.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

msn.com: read the source · also reported by The Sunday Guardian, Inventiva

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India rolls out first Services Production Index, covering 60% of the sector

India has launched its first-ever Services Production Index to measure short-term economic output in the services sector. The newly introduced index covers approximately 60 percent of the total services sector in the country. The rollout coincides with the festive season when e-commerce platforms and retail markets experience heightened economic activity. The initiative aims to provide timely data for policymakers to track high-frequency economic trends in services. Cybersecurity advisories were also issued as shoppers hunt for bargains during current festive sales. Global financial markets simultaneously experienced modest declines and volatility driven by tech-led selloffs and interest rate concerns.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Government statistical authorities · **Prelims:** India rolled out its first Services Production Index.; The index covers 60 percent of the services sector.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Enhances the measurement of short-term economic activity in a vital segment of the economy.; Aids macroeconomic policymaking by providing high-frequency data for the services sector.*

Static — Economic indices in India are primarily compiled and published by official government bodies like the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation. High-frequency economic indicators help policymakers assess the trajectory of gross domestic product components between quarterly releases. The services sector constitutes a major share of India's gross domestic product and employment generation.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

ddnews.gov.in: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Global uranium production to dip by 50% by 2040 as demand set to double, says IAEA report; forecast could pinch India too

A recent IAEA report projects that global uranium mining production will drop by at least 50% by 2040. Global uranium demand is set to double, projecting requirements to reach between 90,045 tU and 1,42,631 tU by 2050. The report, known as the Red Book, was jointly prepared by the Nuclear Energy Agency and the IAEA. Conversion capacity is currently insufficient and will fall further behind demand through 2040 without major investments. India aims to scale its nuclear capacity from 8,180 MW to 22,480 MW by 2031-32, alongside a long-term goal of 100 GW by 2047. India currently procures uranium domestically via UCIL and through international suppliers like Kazakhstan, Russia, Canada, Australia, Uzbekistan, and France. Developing new uranium mines takes 10 to 15 years on average, necessitating immediate sustained exploration and investments.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) and Uranium Corporation of India Limited (UCIL) · **Prelims:** Global uranium requirements are projected to reach up to 1,42,631 tU in the high-case scenario by 2050.; India's current nuclear power capacity stands at 8,180 MW.; India has received in-principle approval to set up a nuclear power plant at Kovvada in Srikakulam district, Andhra Pradesh, in cooperation with the USA.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Threatens India's national goal of achieving 100 GW of nuclear capacity by 2047.; Highlights the urgent need for India to secure long-term international supply arrangements and advance its closed fuel cycle technologies.*

Static — The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) is the world's central intergovernmental forum for scientific and technical cooperation in the nuclear field, set up in 1957. The Nuclear Energy Agency (NEA) is an intergovernmental agency under the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) that facilitates cooperation on nuclear energy. Uranium Corporation of India Limited (UCIL) is a public sector enterprise under the Department of Atomic Energy responsible for uranium mining and processing.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

Times of India: read the source

Infrastructure & Energy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India adds record 6.05 GW wind capacity in FY26, total installed capacity crosses 56 GW

India added a record 6.05 gigawatts of wind energy capacity during the financial year 2025–26. This surge represents a 46 per cent increase compared to the previous fiscal year's additions. The growth is aimed at accelerating onshore deployment to meet India's 500 GW non-fossil energy target by 2030. With this addition, India's total cumulative installed wind power capacity has crossed 56 gigawatts. Key states driving the expansion include Gujarat, Karnataka, and Maharashtra through wind-solar hybrids and open access initiatives. The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy cited interventions like concessional customs duty and ISTS charge waivers until 2028. Dedicated renewable consumption obligation frameworks and competitive bidding mechanisms also propelled project execution. Technical support was provided by the National Institute of Wind Energy to strengthen sector capabilities. The sustained momentum is expected to enhance investor confidence and reinforce India's global clean energy standing.

When: Financial Year 2025–26 · **Where:** India (notably Gujarat, Karnataka, and Maharashtra) · **Who:** Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) and National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE) · **Prelims:** Total cumulative installed wind energy capacity has exceeded 56 GW.; Inter-State Transmission System (ISTS) charge waivers for renewables extend until 2028.; National Institute of Wind Energy (NIWE) provides

technical support to the sector.

Why it matters — *Accelerates progress towards India's Panchamrit climate goals and net-zero emissions targets.; Strengthens grid integration and reliability through the proliferation of complementary wind-solar hybrid projects.*

Static — The Ministry of New and Renewable Energy is the nodal ministry for all matters relating to wind, solar, and bio-energy in India. The National Institute of Wind Energy is an autonomous R&D institution established in Chennai in 1998 under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy. India committed at COP26 to install 500 GW of non-fossil electricity capacity and achieve net-zero carbon emissions by 2070.

Syllabus: GS3: Infrastructure & Energy

ddnews.gov.in: read the source

Internal Security

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Army Officer's Wife Shared Info With Chinese Agents Posing As Academicians

The wife of a senior Army officer has been charged by Jammu and Kashmir police for allegedly passing sensitive information to foreign intelligence operatives. The trigger was an input from a reliable source alleging her involvement in collecting and transmitting secret documents and electronic data. The core issue highlights the threat of intellectual traps where foreign agents pose as academicians to extract classified defence details. Chinese operatives initially contacted her to write articles on geopolitics and environment before shifting focus to sensitive defence issues. An FIR No. 290/2026 has been registered at Gandhi Nagar Police Station under Sections 3 and 5 of the Official Secrets Act. Charges have also been filed under Sections 152 and 61(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for acts prejudicial to national security. Investigators suspect the information was transmitted through encrypted communication channels to individuals linked to China and other foreign nations. Preliminary investigations indicate she may have fallen into the trap unknowingly, though the exact extent of transferred data remains under probe.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** Jammu and Kashmir · **Who:** Jammu and Kashmir Police, Chinese intelligence operatives, Wife of a senior Army officer · **Prelims:** FIR registered: FIR No. 290/2026 at Gandhi Nagar Police Station.; Sections invoked: Sections 3 and 5 of the Official Secrets Act, 1923, and Sections 152 and 61(2) of the BNS.; Accused profile: Resident of Telangana residing in Jammu, wife of a senior Army officer.

Why it matters — *Highlights the growing security vulnerability concerning cyber espionage and honey-trapping or intellectual trapping of military families.; Demonstrates the stringent application of the Official Secrets Act and BNS provisions in modern counter-intelligence operations.*

Static — The Official Secrets Act (OSA), 1923 is India's principal anti-espionage legislation enacted during the British colonial period to govern matters of secrecy and confidentiality. Section 3 of the OSA deals with penalties for spying, penalizing anyone who approaches, inspects, or communicates secret official codes, passwords, sketches, or documents. Section 5 of the OSA punishes wrongful communication of information, targeting individuals entrusted with official secrets who disclose them to unauthorized persons.

Syllabus: GS3: Internal Security, Defence

NDTV: read the source · *free copy on ndtv.com*

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Why Russia Offers Sweeping Su-57E ToT Concessions to India? Overcoming Production Deficits and Boost Export Pitch Amid Sanctions

The development comes as Russia seeks to boost its export pitch and counter production deficits caused by sanctions. Russia is offering sweeping Transfer of Technology concessions to India for the Su-57E fighter jet to overcome production shortfalls.

When: 2026-10-18 · **Where:** Russia and India · **Who:** Russian defense exporters and Indian defense authorities · **Prelims:** The aircraft involved is the Su-57E fighter jet.; The concessions offered include sweeping Transfer of Technology.; Russia faces production deficits and export challenges amid sanctions.

Why it matters — *It impacts India's futuristic fighter aircraft acquisition plans and fifth-generation capabilities.; It tests India's policy of defense indigenization versus quick military capability acquisition.*

Static — Transfer of Technology in defense involves sharing manufacturing know-how, blueprints, and technical data with the recipient nation. India's defense procurement policy increasingly emphasizes indigenous manufacturing and the Make in India initiative. Russia has historically been India's largest defense supplier, providing platforms like the Su-30MKI and S-400 systems.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence, International Relations

Defence.in: read the source

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY SCHEME QUICK READ

Martian Moons Exploration Mission

Japan is preparing to launch the Martian Moons eXploration mission to study Phobos using its H3 rocket. The mission is led by the Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency and targets the unexploited Martian moon Phobos. The mission aims to observe the topography, internal structure, composition, and gravity of Phobos. It aims to collect at least 10 grams of surface material from Phobos and return it to Earth by 2031.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

DEFENCE EXERCISE QUICK READ

Exercise Akhand Prahar-II

The Indian Army conducted a military exercise named Exercise Akhand Prahar-II in Rajasthan. The drill was executed to strengthen combat readiness and evaluate operational preparedness in desert terrain. The exercise focused on validating multi-domain operational capability and integrating modern technological assets into battlefield drills. The operation was jointly carried out by the Black Mace Brigade and the Battle Axe Division.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY SCHEME QUICK READ

PUFFINS Telescope Mission

Bengaluru-born astronomer Dr. Ramya Anche will lead the $20 million NASA space telescope mission named PUFFINS. The mission is selected under NASA's Astrophysics Pioneers programme as a NASA-funded SmallSat initiative. It is a joint effort involving the University of Arizona, McDonald Observatory, and various other scientists. The SmallSat will carry a telescope with an approximate 10-inch aperture to observe the ultraviolet light of around 70 stars.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

ECONOMY SCHEME QUICK READ

Tamil Nadu unveils semiconductor scheme with 25 per cent subsidy

The policy was announced to boost high-tech manufacturing and establish Tamil Nadu as a major semiconductor hub in India. Tamil Nadu has launched a dedicated semiconductor scheme offering a 25 per cent subsidy to attract investments into the sector.

ET Datacenters: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION JUDGMENT ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

Supreme Court Dismisses Appeals Challenging Textile Packing Notification — Upholds Constitutional Validity. The notification mandating packing of yarn in hank form was upheld as constitutional under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.

The Supreme Court delivered its verdict dismissing the appeals challenging the textile packing notification. The Supreme Court dismissed appeals challenging the constitutional validity of the notification that mandates packing yarn in hank form under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.

Lawtext: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY SPECIES PLACE IN NEWS QUICK READ

Valmiki Tiger Reserve to Become Bihar’s Vulture Conservation Hub

Valmiki Tiger Reserve in Bihar has initiated vulture conservation efforts within its Gonauli forest range. The planned development aims to establish the reserve as India’s 9th vulture conservation and breeding centre. Vultures are vital scavenging birds that feed on carrion, preventing pathogen spread and maintaining ecosystem health. Vulture populations suffered major declines historically due to veterinary diclofenac, which triggers kidney failure in birds.

drishtiias.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY SPECIES PLACE IN NEWS QUICK READ

New wolf snake species named after Steve Irwin discovered on remote Indian island

The discovery was recently announced and reported by Bioengineer.org on October 18, 2026. Researchers have discovered a new species of wolf snake on a remote Indian island and named it in honor of Steve Irwin.

Bioengineer.org: source

HISTORY, ART & CULTURE REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Brihadiswara Temple

The Archaeological Survey of India has launched conservation works on the upper rampart of the Brihadiswara Temple in Thanjavur. This conservation initiative aims to preserve the structural integrity and heritage of the historic temple. The core issue involves protecting ancient monuments from structural degradation while maintaining their historical architecture. The Brihadiswara Temple is a Hindu temple dedicated to Lord Shiva and located in Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

ECONOMY REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Japan expected to rank sixth in Global GDP Rankings by 2027, IMF

India is poised to become the world's fourth-largest economy in 2027, overtaking Japan in nominal GDP terms according to an IMF report analysis. India's economy is projected to reach about $4.5 trillion by 2027, driven by robust economic growth despite an uncertain global backdrop. The projected economic shift will push Japan down to the sixth position globally, placing it behind both India and the United Kingdom.

ianslive.in: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY QUICK READ

Delhi draft e-rickshaw policy proposes 2.5 lakh vehicle cap, ownership limits, stricter rules

The Delhi government proposed capping the number of e-rickshaws in the capital at 2.5 lakh through a draft policy. The draft policy aims to address serious concerns regarding traffic congestion, road safety hazards, air and noise pollution, and unregulated growth. Individual owners are restricted to owning a maximum of five e-rickshaws and must be residents of Delhi.

Hindustan Times: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY QUICK READ

Union Cabinet Approves Rs. 12,200 Crore Thane Integral Ring Metro Rail Project

The Union Cabinet gave its official approval to the major infrastructure project. The Union Cabinet has approved the Thane Integral Ring Metro Rail Project with an estimated financial outlay of Rs. 12,200 crore to enhance urban transport.

Elets Technomedia: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY SCHEME QUICK READ

Maryam Nawaz launches second phase of laptop, scholarship schemes

Maryam Nawaz has launched the second phase of student laptop and scholarship schemes for the Punjab province. Information Minister Azma Bokhari announced the launch on Sunday, emphasizing technology and professional skills. The government stated that initiatives focus on education, youth development, and artificial intelligence rather than political slogans. Bokhari criticized political opponents for personal attacks and argued that sit-ins do not help youth.

msn.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

Putin’s India visit for BRICS Summit will provide opportunity to discuss bilateral ties: Kremlin

Russian President Vladimir Putin will visit India for the 18th BRICS Leaders' Summit, enabling bilateral talks, according to Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov. The trip is scheduled ahead of the summit taking place in Delhi on September 12-13 under India's 2026 BRICS chairship. The visit underscores pragmatic bilateral relations and ongoing diplomatic coordination despite geopolitical tensions and Western sanctions against Moscow.

ddnews.gov.in: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION JUDGMENT QUICK READ

CJI Surya Kant to inaugurate Ladakh's first permanent High Court Bench in Leh

Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant will inaugurate the first permanent bench of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh in Leh. The initiative addresses the long-standing difficulties faced by people in remote areas in accessing higher judicial institutions due to geography and harsh weather. Residents seeking judicial relief like writ petitions will no longer need to travel long distances to Srinagar or Jammu.

The Hindu: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

Failed UPI, ATM or card payment? Here's when you'll get Rs. 100 per day for a delayed refund

Bank customers can receive compensation of Rs. 100 per day if funds for a failed transaction are not reversed within the prescribed deadline. A failed transaction is an incomplete transaction caused by communication errors, ATM cash shortages, timeouts, or uncredited beneficiary accounts. The Reserve Bank of India framework mandates that compensation must be credited automatically without requiring the customer to file a formal claim.

msn.com: source

DEFENCE QUICK READ

YJ-21 Missile

Chinese state media released footage showing the launch of a YJ-21 anti-ship ballistic missile by a People’s Liberation Army H-6K bomber. This release comes eight years after the missile was first unveiled and highlights the expansion of China's military capabilities. The core issue involves the strategic threat posed by advanced hypersonic anti-ship missiles to large, high-value naval assets like aircraft carriers.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

ECONOMY REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Faster services imports threaten to erode cushion against India's goods trade deficit: Report

India's services trade surplus is facing pressure as services imports grow faster than exports, according to an ICICI Bank research report. The emerging concern is that faster services import growth could reduce net foreign exchange earnings and weaken the cushion against the goods trade deficit. Net services exports declined by 10 per cent year-on-year to USD 16.9 billion in September 2026.

Economic Times: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY REPORT/INDEX ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

Karnataka brings government employees' services under Sakala Act; hefty fines for delays and malicious complaints

The decision was taken following recommendations from the seventh report of the Administrative Reforms Commission-2. The Karnataka government has extended the Sakala Act to cover internal staff services of government employees, ensuring time-bound delivery with provisions for fines on delays. Following recommendations from the seventh report of the Administrative Reforms Commission-2, time-bound delivery of internal staff services has been extended across all field-level departments and organisations

The Hindu: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

DoRD and PFRDA sign MoU, 'Pension Sakhis' to expand reach in rural India

The Department of Rural Development and PFRDA signed an MoU to expand pension coverage and social security in rural areas. The partnership aims to raise pension awareness, facilitate enrolment, and provide support using a dedicated cadre called Pension Sakhis. The initiative leverages the DAY-NRLM network, including Banking Correspondent Sakhis and community resource persons, to reach underserved groups.

ddnews.gov.in: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY QUICK READ

NGT pulls up Karnataka officials, orders notices over pollution in Thenpennai river

The National Green Tribunal pulled up Karnataka officials for wilful disobedience and non-compliance with its orders regarding pollution of the Thenpennai River. The Tribunal acted suo motu following reports of chemical frothing in the river in 2020 and toxic foam in Hosur in 2024. The Bench issued notices to the Karnataka chief secretary, BWSSB chairperson, and heads of forest and municipal administration departments.

timesofindia.indiatimes.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS EXERCISE QUICK READ

Pakistan, China conducting joint military exercise Karakoram 2026

Pakistan and China launched their joint military exercise named Karakoram 2026. The opening ceremony of the exercise took place in Korla, a city located in China's Xinjiang region. The drills focus heavily on counterterrorism operations, drone warfare, precision shooting, and enhanced battlefield coordination. Participating troops are engaging in specialised training involving drone operations, detection of moving targets, and live-fire drills.

msn.com: source

ECONOMY SCHEME QUICK READ

EPFO scheme offers up to Rs. 15,000 to first-time employees: Check eligibility, salary limit and payment rules

Eligible first-time employees joining the formal workforce can receive an incentive of up to Rs 15,000 under the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana. The scheme is administered through the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation to encourage formal employment by rewarding workers entering the EPF system for the first time.

msn.com: source

HEALTH AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

From Goa to Iowa: AIIA signs MoUs to strengthen child healthcare and global Ayurveda education

The signing of these strategic MoUs by AIIA put the institution in the news. The All India Institute of Ayurveda has signed MoUs ranging from Goa to Iowa to improve child healthcare and advance global Ayurveda education.

NE India Broadcast: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY QUICK READ

Shivraj Singh Chouhan launches National Scholarship Portal; over 6,000 receive Rs 21.35 crore through NSP-DBT

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan launched a National Scholarship Portal-based system for agriculture students at ICAR-IARI, Pusa. The portal was introduced to curb administrative delays and ensure seamless, monthly direct scholarship disbursements to agricultural scholars. The reform addresses systemic issues in academic welfare delivery, ensuring transparency and reducing intermediaries through direct benefit transfers.

ddnews.gov.in: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

India GDP Growth Forecast Raised to 7% for FY27 and FY28

Deloitte has raised India's GDP growth forecast to 7% for both FY27 and FY28, citing improved business conditions and private investment recovery. Stronger corporate balance sheets, better connectivity, and higher capacity utilisation are key factors supporting fresh capital expenditure. Gross fixed capital formation expanded by 11.9% in the first quarter of FY27, recording its fastest growth in four years.

freepressjournal.in: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION JUDGMENT QUICK READ

Fact Check: ECI calls Rahul Gandhi 'Illegal form 6 change' claim misleading, cites Bihar SIR verdict by Supreme Court

It came in the news after the ECI responded to claims regarding voter registration modifications by citing a Supreme Court verdict. The Election Commission of India has dismissed Rahul Gandhi's allegations about illegal Form 6 changes, calling them misleading.

Organiser: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 The verdict-first dissent: India's politics of negation

The ongoing street protests and opposition marches demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. This protest movement manifests Martin Gurri's thesis in The Revolt of the Public, where digital-age publics mobilise to challenge existing authorities through negation rather than building alternative institutions. The core debate centers on the removal of over 1.3 crore names from draft rolls, which the opposition terms vote theft and the Election Commission calls routine administrative cleanup.

Deccan Herald

GS3 Pivot to Privatisation 2.0: Why IDBI Bank's sale should rev up India's push to privatise remaining PSUs

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approved the sale of a combined 60.72% stake in IDBI Bank held by the government and LIC to Fairfax Financial Holdings Ltd's Canadian subsidiary. The sale will fetch Rs. 26,544 crore for the government and Rs. 26,335 crore for LIC, marking a major milestone in India's privatisation programme. The author argues that privatising loss-making or restructured public sector units frees up fiscal resources and improves corporate efficiency.

Economic Times

GS3 The Indian economy has displayed growth resilience—but fault lines have grown too that can't be papered over

An opinion piece in Mint highlighted emerging structural risks and economic vulnerabilities facing India. The Indian economy shows growth resilience, but rising structural fault lines like inflation, gold stashes, and potential asset bubbles threaten stability. A storm may be brewing on account of structural weaknesses that mustn't catch policymakers off-guard. Among our worries should be growing household stashes of gold, the fallout of El Niño, generalized inflation, rising interest rates and a potential AI bubble burst.

Mint

GS3 Yes Bank AT-1 verdict: Does this instrument fulfil the purpose it was originally designed for?

The Supreme Court delivered a ruling on Yes Bank AT-1 bonds, triggering debates on bank supervision and insolvency resolution. An editorial analyzing the Supreme Court verdict on Yes Bank AT-1 bonds and questioning whether the instrument fulfils its original design purpose. The Supreme Court's ruling should prompt neither triumphalism among bondholders nor defensiveness among regulators. It should trigger a serious reconsideration of AT-1's economic rationale, the quality of bank supervision and the legal foundations of insolvency resolution.

Mint

GS3 IMF outlook: The global economy may not be doing as badly as feared but it's laden with major risks

The release of the latest International Monetary Fund economic forecast and its accompanying qualifiers put the global economic outlook in the news. The International Monetary Fund has issued a cautious economic outlook indicating that while the global economy has avoided worst-case scenarios, significant risks remain. Rarely has a fairly positive forecast from the International Monetary Fund (IMF) had so many qualifiers. The predictions aren't so much cause for celebration as a recognition that the worst hasn't come to pass.

Mint

GS3 Recontextualising industrial policy: Lessons from the East Asian developmental state

Industrial policy has seen a rapid revival since the COVID-19 pandemic due to geopolitical crises, supply-chain disruptions, and surging Chinese exports deindustrialising nations. Current discussions around industrial policy often ignore the sociopolitical and institutional bargains that made it successful in East and Southeast Asia. Industrial policy must be fundamentally reinterpreted against modern realities like state capacity, political capital, global macroeconomics, and evolving geopolitics.

Hindustan Times

GS2 The right, gutsy choice for the 2026 Nobel Peace prize

The 2026 Nobel Peace Prize was awarded to South African jurist Navanethem Navi Pillay, marking a bold and historic choice by the Oslo committee. The selection is considered gutsy because it reverses a US narrative and honours Pillay despite Donald Trump s publicly aired aspirations for the prize. The core issue centres on Pillay s fearless stance as chair of the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory.

Hindustan Times

GS3 Ecosystem services and role of farmers

It is in the news as an opinion piece addressing the systemic undervaluation of ecological contributions made by farmers in modern agricultural economies. The editorial argues that agricultural support policies must shift beyond visible crop output to recognize and reward farmers for vital hidden ecosystem services like carbon storage and groundwater recharge. While support for agriculture focuses mainly on the visible part of farming, little attention is given to groundwater recharge, carbon storage or pollination

BusinessLine

GS1 GS2 Crimes against women, control, and the railways

The editorial examines the history of violent crimes against women on Indian railways and its link to patriarchal control over women's mobility. A notable historical trigger was the 1868 death of a woman on the East India Railway after being assaulted by a European named Samuel Horn. The core argument highlights how train travel historically threatened traditional female seclusion or purdah and the rigid separation of public and private spheres.

Hindustan Times

GS1 GS2 Poison for some, medicine for others: How Ambedkar’s writings challenge caste hierarchies in India

The persistent relevance of Ambedkar's critique of caste in contemporary socio-political debates. An opinion piece analyzing the enduring impact of B.R. Ambedkar's writings in challenging and dismantling caste hierarchies in India. Poison for some, medicine for others

Deccan Herald

GS3 What's wrong with calling it an 'AI race'? A lot—and India should reject this notion outright

The commentary highlights concerns over the pervasive narrative of an international 'AI race' shaping national technology strategies. The author argues that AI development lacks the defining conditions of a race and urges India to reject the race metaphor to prevent distorted resource allocation. For something to be called a race, it must fulfil three conditions, which the competitive pursuit of AI does not. India should resist this idea before it distorts resource allocation— and focus instead on deploying AI to its advantage.

Mint

GS2 In countries with written constitution, people are the final authority in everything: Morarji Desai

Democracy rests on four pillars namely the legislature, executive, judiciary, and the press, which must all be independent and free. All freedoms, including those of the four pillars, are ultimately subordinate to the freedom of society and the people. In countries with written constitutions like India, the people are the final authority and exercise power through elected representatives. Parliament is supreme within its functions under the Constitution but cannot alter the Constitution in an undemocratic manner or establish a dictatorship.

ThePrint

GS2 Why Iran-US negotiations keep failing

US-Iran diplomatic talks continue to collapse despite substantive convergence because of entrenched psychological complexes stemming from past crises. The rupture began with the 1953 Anglo-American coup against Mohammad Mosaddegh and the 1979 Tehran US embassy hostage crisis. Washington operates under an embassy siege complex demanding Iranian concessions and verification before offering any reciprocal relief. Tehran functions under a JCPOA withdrawal complex requiring binding guarantees and sanctions relief before making any compromises.

Al Jazeera

GS1 Why the British Raj counted India’s infirm population

The British colonial administration attempted to count persons afflicted with specific infirmities during the first synchronous censuses of 1871-1872 and 1881. The enumeration was driven by administrative, medical, and moral imperatives, including bringing Indian data in alignment with Western metropolitan standards. Colonial officials viewed the census as a tool for practical governance to inform the provision of asylums, hospitals, and poor relief. The process served as a scientific tool for imperial hygiene to assess able-bodied subjects and identify unproductive populations.

ThePrint

GS2 Donald Trump’s midterm election setback may matter less to India

The piece is pegged to discussions around Donald Trump’s political standing and the implications of the midterm elections for international relations. The editorial discusses how a potential midterm election setback for Donald Trump would likely have minimal negative impact on the strategic ties between India and the United States.

Deccan Herald

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Supreme Court address a parental anxiety: How to keep the Internet safe for children The matter came into focus as the Supreme Court addressed parental anxiety regarding keeping the internet safe for children. The Supreme Court addressed concerns about online child safety, stating children are not to be blamed for CSEAM material while holding creators and negligent intermediaries responsible.
The Hindu

What is Iran's 7-day proposal to the US to open the Strait of Hormuz? The proposal emerged amidst escalating maritime tensions and concerns over global energy supply disruptions in the Persian Gulf. Iran proposed a 7-day plan to the United States regarding the opening and secure navigation of the Strait of Hormuz.
Indian Express

Does 'inflation targeting' work in India? It is in the news because recent economic evaluations question the efficacy and societal costs of the RBI's inflation targeting mandate. An analysis of India's inflation targeting framework reveals a flat Phillips curve and persistently high household inflation expectations, raising questions about its cost to output and employment.
The Hindu

Knowledge Nugget | Nagoya Protocol: How does it protect biodiversity and local communities? The Indian Express published a knowledge nugget explaining the function and importance of the Nagoya Protocol. The piece outlines the mechanism of the Nagoya Protocol regarding biodiversity protection and community benefit-sharing.
Indian Express

Trump eases duty threat; penalising India hard to defend for US now The shift in stance on US duty threats against India put the diplomatic and trade development in the news. US President Donald Trump has eased tariff threats against India, making trade penalties difficult for the US to justify.
Indian Express

Why Big Tech is giving away open-weight AI models, and what it wants in return Big Tech firms are distributing open-weight AI models to compete with Chinese developers and secure platform adoption. Technology companies are releasing open-weight artificial intelligence models, including Beam and Nemotron, to attract developers and build their ecosystems.
The Hindu

France protests blow up: What exactly is wrong with its economy? The issue is in the news due to recent protests blowing up over economic troubles in France. France is experiencing significant protests linked to underlying structural problems and fiscal challenges within its economy.
Indian Express

What drives corporate investment? It is in the news because corporate investment as a share of GDP continues to stay low despite policy interventions like tax cuts. An analysis of the factors driving corporate investment in India, highlighting the post-demonetisation decline and the role of demand, interest rates, and government expenditure.
The Hindu

60 Days, No Punitive Tariffs: What Trump's Sanctions Waiver On Russian Oil Means For India US President Donald Trump temporarily waived key provisions of the Graham Act, pausing threatened punitive tariffs of up to 100% on countries like India and China purchasing Russian oil and gas. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio explained that the administration needs 60 days to study broader economic and geopolitical impacts before determining next steps.
news18.com

China This Week | FM Sitharaman to Europe, growing focus on Chinese trade surplus The development is in the news due to FM Sitharaman's ongoing diplomatic and economic visit to Europe alongside heightened scrutiny of Chinese trade practices. This explainer covers Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman's visit to Europe and the rising global policy focus on China's massive trade surplus.
Indian Express

Word of the Week is Starlink: How Elon Musk's satellite company is at the heart of new US-Ukraine tensions The topic is in the news as the Word of the Week, examining how the satellite company impacts US-Ukraine geopolitical relations. Starlink, the satellite internet service owned by Elon Musk's SpaceX, has emerged at the center of growing tensions between the United States and Ukraine.
Firstpost

This Week in Explainers: Why is Saudi Arabia struggling to shield itself from Houthi attacks? The ongoing regional security dynamics and continuous threat posed by Houthi missile and drone strikes put the topic in the news. An explainer detailing the reasons behind Saudi Arabia's persistent vulnerability to aerial attacks by Houthi forces from Yemen.
Firstpost

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- Global Monetary Tightening, Why Central Banks Have Limited Options (Economy) Vajiram & Ravi
- India-New Zealand FTA to boost New Delhi's trade diversification strategy (Economy) Business Standard
- RBI may need to raise repo rate to 6.25% as inflation risks persist: SBI Mutual Fund (Economy) www.malaysiasun.com
- Ukraine launches largest aerial attack on Russia's oil infrastructure (International Relations) All India Radio (NewsOnAir)

- India’s Nutrient-Rich Purple Potato (Agriculture & Allied) PIB
- India needs policy credibility and continuity to sustain FDI as strong growth alone is not enough, says KIEP expert (Economy) Economic Times
- India vs China in 40 years: TRUST MF CIO Mihir Vora - 'India compounded GDP growth at 7.3%; China broke out at 11.3%' (Economy) Mint
- Heavy overnight rain batters Chennai as Northeast monsoon gets active in Tamil Nadu (Disaster Management) The Hindu
- Tiger reserve officials of TN, Karnataka and Kerala meet to discuss coordinated efforts (Environment & Ecology) The New Indian Express
- India Infrastructure Push: Highway awards surge 62.9 percent, renewable capacity grows 29.5 percent (Economy) Organiser
- CNAP Caller Name Identification, India’s New Telecom Rule Explained (Governance & Policy) Vajiram & Ravi
- Maharashtra declares 40 more talukas drought-hit, announces Rs. 5,000 aid for farmers (Agriculture & Allied) The Hindu
- St. Petersburg oil facilities ablaze as Ukraine launches more than 1,000 drones at Russia (International Relations) The Hindu
- Commerce, Finance Ministries at odds over future of key export support schemes (Economy) BusinessLine
- FSSAI issues notices to major companies over misleading labels on ready-to-drink dairy beverages (Governance & Policy) All India Radio (NewsOnAir)
- ‘Poshakamrutham’ scheme launched in Ernakulam (Social Justice & Welfare) The Hindu
- LOKAYAN 2026 – INDIAN NAVAL SHIP SUDARSHINI DEPARTS SALALAH, OMAN (Defence) PIB
- Latest rainfall data highlights severe threat to rabi crops amid deficits and El Niño concerns (Agriculture & Allied) BusinessLine
- Pakistan extends airspace ban on Indian aircraft till November 24 (International Relations) The Hindu
- DMK, YSRCP backing CEC’s removal clouds Centre’s delimitation push ahead of possible Parliament session (Polity & Constitution) The New Indian Express
- Sariska Tiger Reserves Tiger Count Rises To 58 As Tigress ST-26 Is Spotted With Two Cubs (Environment & Ecology) Free Press Journal
- India's exports to West Asia recover from US-Iran war shock in April-August; shipments to Africa, ASEAN rise (Economy) Mint
- AI cuts job demand in exposed occupations by nearly 10% across Asia: IMF report (Economy) Times of India
- Indian refiners' fuel exports to West rise 43% amid Russian crude use (Economy) Business Standard
- CARA referral doesn’t give enforceable right to adopt child if legally ineligible: Delhi HC (Social Justice & Welfare) Hindustan Times
- "A Mistake": Jagan Mohan Reddy Regrets Backing 2023 Election Commission Law (Polity & Constitution) NDTV
- Dr. Abhilaksh Likhi, Union Secretary, Department of Fisheries, Visits Munsyari Coldwater Fisheries Cluster; Interacts with Trout Farmers and Reviews Cluster Development Initiatives (Agriculture & Allied) PIB
- Telangana seeks drought relief measures from Centre (Agriculture & Allied) The Hindu
- Karnataka extends online RTI filing to all Bengaluru One, Karnataka One and Grama One centres (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Hampi hosts UNESCO conservation review from 24 to 29 October (History, Art & Culture) ad-hoc-news.de
- UN Report Finds 1.2 Billion People in Poverty as Afghanistan Faces Deepening Crisis (International Relations) Khaama Press
- Kerala High Court denies stay on government order reconstituting State Waqf Board (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Tourism infrastructure threatens to push elephants out of Mattupetty grasslands in Keralam’s Munnar (Environment & Ecology) The Hindu
- Six Yellow Loosestrife Species Recorded for the First Time in Manipur, India (Environment & Ecology) bioengineer.org
- As rising waters flood homes and temples, villagers protest India's US$87 billion river-linking project (Infrastructure & Energy) Awani International
- SC panel launches portal for complaints on alleged police excesses during July youth protests (Internal Security) Scroll
- Cyprus flags Turkey’s defiance of UN resolutions, backs India’s UNSC bid (International Relations) The Sunday Guardian
- India’s soybean output seen falling 2.1% to 107.93 lakh tonnes in Kharif 2026: Farmers' body (Agriculture & Allied) Economic Times
- TAJIKISTAN-DUSHANBE-CHINA-LI QIANG-OFFICIAL VISIT-SCO MEETING-ARRIVAL (International Relations) www.indiagazette.com
- India and Mongolia Deepen Defence Partnership, Focus on Military Training and Cybersecurity (International Relations) www.nationpathindia.com
- Bilawal says KP governor’s rule, emergency could end if opposition agrees on joint anti-terrorism plan (International Relations) Daily Pakistan
- Karnataka revises penalties for officials, false grievances under new Act (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Deleted voter names can be restored through Form 6, ECI tells Delhi High Court (Polity & Constitution) Daily Pioneer
- Political situation in Bangladesh stabilised; concerns remain over graft,reforms: UK (International Relations) United News of Bangladesh
- Supreme Court Upholds Union of India's Appeal in Central Excise Duty Case — Clarifies Interpretation of Provisos in Excise Rules. (Polity & Constitution) Lawtext
- BIMSTEC’s Collective Resolve (International Relations) Daily Excelsior
- India-Czech Defence Partnership Focuses On Ammunition Technology And Local Manufacturing (Defence) ABP Live English
- UPSC Ethics Simplified | Kerala Mini Cooper crash: What would Mill, Berlin and Sartre say? (Ethics & Integrity) Indian Express

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 17 must-know, 26 Prelims facts, 48 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (10), Polity & Constitution (8), Governance & Policy (7), International Relations (4), Defence (3), Environment & Ecology (3), Infrastructure & Energy (2), Science & Technology (2), Internal Security (1), Social Justice & Welfare (1), History, Art & Culture (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in —** Education, Agriculture & Allied, Disaster Management, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 2 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 2 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 3

Full text — 41 of 70 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 9, Hindustan Times 6, msn.com 6, ddnews.gov.in 5, Vajiram & Ravi 5, Indian Express 5, Mint 4, Times of India 3, Deccan Herald 3, Lawtext 2, Economic Times 2, ThePrint 2, Firstpost 2, indianmasterminds.com 1

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